

14 > Separate Digital Identities

Before attaching a phone number, ask:

1. Is it mandatory to create the account?
2. Is it used for login, public discovery, security or marketing?
3. Can other users find the account by uploading contacts?
4. Can a hardware security key, passkey or authenticator replace SMS?
5. Can the number be hidden from other users?
6. What happens if the number is reassigned or lost?

Payment creates another powerful bridge. A pseudonymous storefront, donation page or subscription may still be connected internally to a bank card, UPI account, billing address or tax record. Do not promise anonymity to yourself or others when a regulated payment provider knows your identity. Instead, distinguish between being pseudonymous to the public and identified to the service handling the transaction.

Never use another person's payment account, KYC documents or phone number merely to preserve a compartment. That transfers risk to them and may cross legal boundaries.

Step 6: Reduce behavioural linkability

Even perfectly separated accounts can be connected through behaviour. Writing style, repeated spelling mistakes, posting schedules, favourite expressions, recurring stories and immediate cross-posting all create patterns.



You do not need to manufacture a false personality. Remove needless identifying detail. Delay posts that reveal your live location. Avoid publishing the same photograph, opinion or link simultaneously across compartments. Do not mention a rare workplace incident on both a professional profile and a pseudonymous forum. Before posting, ask whether someone familiar with you could recognise the combination of facts.

Contacts can create bridges too. Following the same small circle from every identity makes the relationship visible. Uploading an address book may allow a service to recommend your pseudonymous profile to acquaintances. Keep contact syncing disabled unless the compartment genu-

ESTABLISH OPERATING RULES

A compartment survives through habits, not labels. Write five non-negotiable rules for each identity. For example:

- The Legal profile never installs untested extensions.
- The Work profile never accesses personal social media.
- The Public identity never uses a personal photograph.
- The Commercial address is never used for password recovery.
- The Research compartment never logs into personal accounts.

Create a colour or visual cue for each compartment. Use different browser themes, wallpapers and password-manager vault labels. These cues reduce human error when several identities are open.

inely depends on it, and review discoverability settings after application updates.

Action lab: test your identity map

Choose one ordinary activity, such as joining a discussion forum. Walk through it without creating the account immediately.

First, decide which compartment owns the activity. Second, select the correct browser profile. Third, create or choose the appropriate email alias. Fourth, generate an unrelated username and unique password. Fifth, decline optional contact uploads, location access and profile fields. Sixth, inspect recovery and discoverability settings. Seventh, record the account in your identity map.

Finally, attempt to connect the new identity to yourself using only public clues. Search the username, inspect the avatar, compare biography wording and examine whom the account follows. Ask a trusted person to perform the same test without revealing private information.

Compartmentalisation is not an exhausting theatre of secrecy. It makes disclosure proportional: legal identity where verification is required, professional identity for work, personal identity for relationships and minimal information elsewhere.

A strong system accepts that some compartments will be linked internally while preventing unnecessary public or commercial linkage. The result is not perfect anonymity. It is controlled identity: fewer accidental bridges, smaller consequences when one account is exposed and a clearer boundary between the many roles that make up your digital life. 